

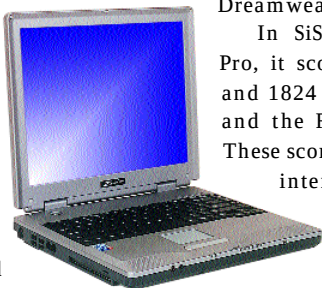
Zenith Portable Desktop

Impressive switchover

At the heart of the Zenith Portable Desktop throbs a P4 1.6 GHz processor and 128 MB of PC266 DDR SDRAM that can be upgraded up to 1 GB. Its 14-inch LCD monitor can be viewed clearly even at a 45-degree angle. However, the Glide-pad buttons feel tacky and the keypad buttons too don't give the perfect spring back feel.

The laptop hosts a Mic-in, Audio Out, FireWire (IEEE 1394), a LAN, a modem, S-Video, parallel port and four USB ports. It also has a Kensington lock. At the time of purchase, you can choose from a range of OS such as Windows XP Home, XP Professional or Windows 2000 Professional.

We ran the benchmarks on Windows XP Professional after loading the necessary drivers and found that the laptop provides decent gaming and onboard sound. In Content Creation Winstone 2001, which measures overall performance, it logged 34.5,



indicating that the performance will be smooth even when running relatively demanding applications such as Photoshop or Dreamweaver.

In SiSoft Sandra 2002 Pro, it scored a high 1817 and 1824 MBps in the ALU and the FPU, respectively.

These scores show that CPU intensive applications will also run smoothly. The laptop logged a sequential read speed of 20 MBps and a sequential write speed of 17 MBps in the SiSoft Sandra HDD benchmark. The average access time was 12 ms, which is quite comparable with desktop PCs.

Overall, this is a decent mobile replacement for a desktop PC. The only drawback is its weight—3 kg.

SPECIFICATIONS

Pentium 4 1.6 GHz processor (Northwood, 512 KB L2 cache), SiS 650 chipset, 128 MB DDR SDRAM, 14-inch XGA TFT monitor with 1024x768 maximum resolution at 60 Hz, integrated 4x graphics, AVANCE onboard soundcard, onboard 56 K modem, onboard LAN

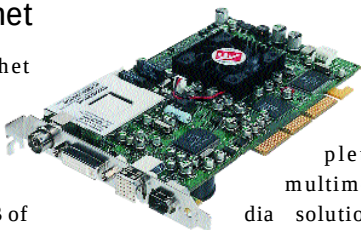
Zenith Portable Desktop B	
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶
Build quality	▶▶▶▶▶
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶
Features	▶▶▶▶▶
OVERALL	▶▶▶▶▶

Price: Rs 68,500
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Web site: www.zenith-india.com

Hercules 3D Prophet All-In-Wonder 8500 DV

Return of the prophet

The Hercules 3D Prophet 8500 DV is a feature-packed graphics card, at the heart of which is the powerful ATi Radeon 8500 (R200) chipset. It has 64 MB of onboard DDR RAM. But what's more interesting is that, apart from providing a powerful GPU, it also provides a com-



plete multimedia solution by featuring a built-in TV Tuner card, video capturing/output features, full hardware DVD decoder and an

IEEE 1394 (FireWire) connector. The package includes Ulead Video Studio 5.0, a radio frequency remote control, a USB receiver and an input adapter. This last item can connect up to 10 devices to the card.

As for the card's performance in the tests, it logged 382 fps in the normal mode in *Quake III Arena*. The score at high and maximum settings was 204 and 126, respectively.

Price: Rs 19,950
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It logged 7303 in 3DMark 2001SE, which suggests a good Direct 3D performance. All in all, this card offers a good multimedia solution.

SPECIFICATIONS

ATi Radeon 8500 (R200) chipset, 64 MB DDR RAM, built-in TV Tuner card, hardware DVD decoder, IEEE1394 connector, Ulead Video Studio 5.0, RF remote control, USB receiver, input adapter that can connect up to 10 devices to the card

Hercules 3D Prophet B	
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶
Build quality	▶▶▶▶▶
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶
Features	▶▶▶▶▶
OVERALL	▶▶▶▶▶

Mercury Wireless Internet Multimedia Keyboard

Connect free!

This is a radio frequency driven keyboard and mouse combination, which can be used within a 2 meter range in any direction and up to 2.5 meters straight.

It incorporates 18 extra function keys for Multimedia, Internet and programmable functions.

The keyboard uses three AA batteries and has an indicator for the battery status. Ironically, there is no indication for Num Lock, Scroll Lock and Caps Lock, though you can set the bundled program to indicate their status in the System Tray. All the features of the keyboard are available only after you install the drivers bundled with it.

The mouse tends to feel a little heavy because of the two AAA batteries. It can be used at a range of up to 1 meter in any direction and 1.5 meters straight. You can configure

three of the five mouse buttons for any function using the drivers provided.



You need to initialise the keyboard and mouse by pressing a small black button placed at the base of the mouse, but this is not mentioned in the manual, nor is there any marking on the device.

If you've been looking for an RF input device, this one comes fairly cheap, but if you're a gamer, you will find the mouse a tad heavy.

SPECIFICATIONS

Keyboard: 2.5 metres range, three AA batteries, standard keyboard, 18 function keys
Mouse: 1.5 metre range, two AAA batteries, five buttons

Mercury Wireless Internet Multimedia Keyboard B+	
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶
Build quality	▶▶▶▶▶
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶
Features	▶▶▶▶▶
OVERALL	▶▶▶▶▶

Price: Rs 2,000
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